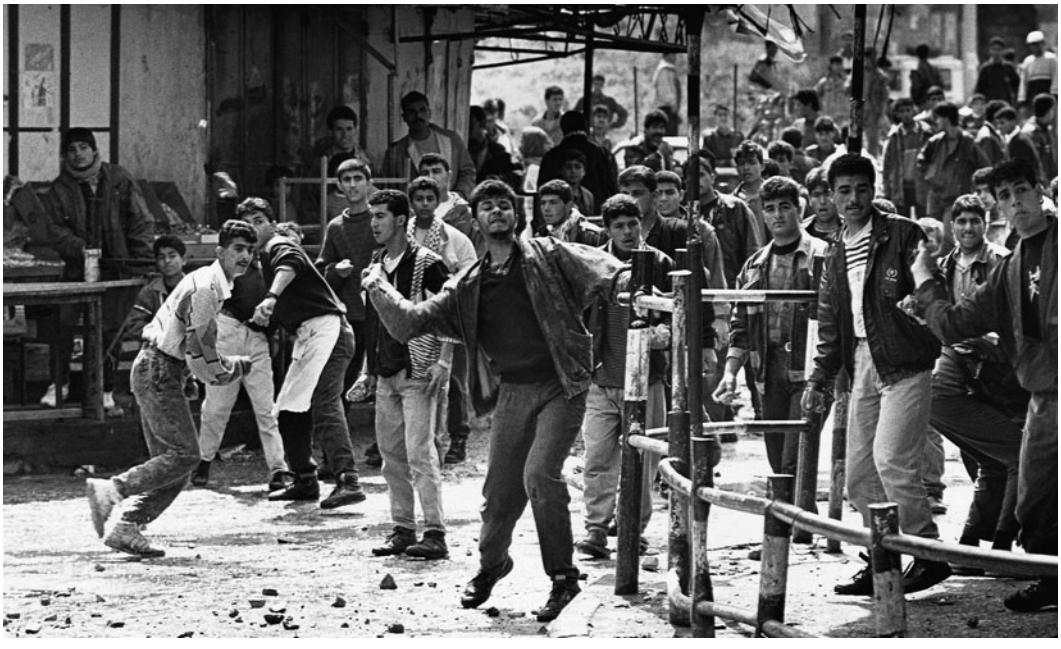


Young Palestinians hurl stones at Israeli soldiers in Gaza in 1987.

around Jerusalem and another 20,000 living in parts of the West Bank and in Gaza. The *Intifada* may have been triggered by a single incident but years of living under Israeli occupation, with all its daily humiliations, had brought the increasing hatred and tension to boiling point.

The outbreak of the *Intifada* 1987

Key question
What was the Israeli response?

The *Intifada* took everyone by surprise: Israel, the PLO, the Arab states and the rest of the world. It was spontaneous and completely unplanned. At first, it mainly consisted of people setting up barricades and throwing stones at Israeli troops. But soon it took the form of huge demonstrations and strikes. It involved children as well as adults, women as well as men, labourers as well as businessmen, villagers as well as townspeople, refugees from the camps as well as shopkeepers. It became a national uprising.

The Israeli response and its effects

Not surprisingly, the Israeli government insisted on an 'iron-fist' policy: their troops used tear gas, water cannons, rubber bullets, even live ammunition. But they could not halt the momentum of the uprising. Newspapers and television around the world showed teenagers being shot by Israeli troops. This led the Israeli government to announce that it would no longer use bullets. Instead, they adopted a policy of 'might, force and beatings'. There were mass arrests and special detention camps were set up. Those thought to be leading the uprising were deported or even assassinated. But there was no end to the *Intifada* and the death rate kept rising. By September 1988, 346 Palestinians had been killed. Many of them were under 16 years of age.